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Yves Congar: Theologian, Ecumenist, and Visionary

Paul J. Philibert, O.P.

When Yves Congar died in the national military hospital of Les Invalides in Paris on June 22, 1995, he was ninety-one years old and had suffered for most of his adult life from the debilitating effects of multiple sclerosis. Yet he was clear and sharp in his thinking until the end and connected to an international network of scholars and church leaders. Hardly a day passed without his receiving a visit from former colleagues and students who included some of the most distinguished authors and professors in universities around the world. His advice and views were sought by theologians, historians, and ecclesiologists and he remained a significant figure in the field of theology until the very end. One of the great masterpieces of his career, his three-volume work on the Holy Spirit (*Je crois en l'Esprit-Saint*) was published when he was in his mid-seventies. Another volume, a collection of articles from 1953 to 1987 entitled *Eglise et Papauté*, appeared in 1994.

The passing of Yves Congar marks the end of an era that saw the convergence of a great number of remarkable theologians living and working together under the powerful motif of conciliar renewal. Like Henri DeLubac, his Jesuit compatriot, Congar was an historian and Patristic scholar as well as a theologian. Both Congar and DeLubac suffered at the hands of the Vatican for their liberating and pastorally engaged theological work.

Central to Congar's life — and to the life of a distinguished cadre of contemporaries like Karl Rahner, Bernard Häring, Josef Jungmann, Hans Küng and Edward Schillebeeckx (all well known in the English-speaking world) — was their cooperation as experts and advisors to the bishops who attended the Second Vatican Council between 1962 and 1965. Providentially, the theological experts at Vatican II represented a witness of competence, erudition, and pastoral experience that deeply influenced the conversations of the conciliar Fathers and the evolution of the conciliar documents. The Second Vatican Council certainly represents both the high point of Congar's life as well as the maximum influence of his passionately committed theological vision.

At Congar's funeral Mass at the Cathedral of Notre Dame in Paris, Father

Timothy Radcliffe, the Dominican Master General, remarked that three great graces had shaped Congar's life: his Dominican life and connections, the friendships formed in the German prison camps of Colditz and Lübeck during the Second World War, and the Second Vatican Council. In each case, these moments of his life gave him both pain and delight. They also illuminate the qualities of Congar's life and contribution: his passion for ecumenism, his solidarity with his theological colleagues in the work of ecclesial *aggiornamento*, and his faith in the future of the Church.

In November 1924, at the age of twenty, Congar was conscripted into the French army for a year of compulsory military service. A year later, in 1925, he left the army with the rank of lieutenant in the infantry and entered the Dominican novitiate in Amiens. Fifteen years later, as a priest of thirty-five, he was called back into active service for a period that lasted six years. In the summer of 1940, he was taken prisoner by the Germans.

In coming years Congar would speak frequently of having lost five years of theological research, but his later life was to prove that these were not "lost" years at all. Living and laboring in this grim context of Nazi camps, he experienced intimate contact as a priest with laity, as a Catholic with Protestants, and as a believer with non-believers. He also learned German as well, a skill that became invaluable for his future historical research, his access to modern theology, and his ecumenical study and contacts. When he could, he functioned as a chaplain or gave lectures on the Bible or on theology to his fellow prisoners. Twice he attempted to escape — and paid the price of having his freedom curtailed.

He himself would finally say that he became a stronger and more free human being as a result of his experiences and his comrades in captivity. His vocation to ecumenism, realized already in his seminary days, was confirmed by his war experiences. As a graduate student in France in 1967, I once heard him say in conversation at Le Saulchoir that in the camps he missed his books and his study, but he discovered in a way that he had never perceived elsewhere the common life that all Christians share in the word of God and the mutual love of the Holy Spirit. Important facets of Congar's theology were forged in his five years of captivity.

After completing his Dominican novitiate in 1926, Congar began his theological studies at Le Saulchoir, the *studium generale* or seminary of the Paris Dominicans. Le Saulchoir began in a situation of exile in Belgium. In 1903, Catholic religious had been expelled once again from France by the Republican government, and so the theological faculty of the Province of France then settled into a Belgian town known as Kain-lez-Tournai not far from the French city of Lille and near the city of Tournai. During its period of exile and after 1938 when it moved back to France near Paris, Le Saulchoir became one of the leading intellectual centers for the historical and cultural study of medieval the-

ology, especially for the historical study of the theology of the great thirteenth century Dominican theologian, St. Thomas Aquinas.

The great goal of the Director of Le Saulchoir, Père Ambroise Gardeil (Regent of Studies from 1894-1911), was to bring theological study up to the level of the highest expectations of serious university research. By the time Congar began his studies at Le Saulchoir in 1926, a superlative faculty was assembled there whose common motto was “*aux données de la foi — aux sources!*” — “back to the scriptures, back to the sources!” Congar took naturally and easily to this regime and was guided by his life-long Dominican friend and colleague, M.-D. Chenu, a mentor slightly older than himself and someone gifted in awakening in others his passion for history.

In due time Congar became part of the faculty of Le Saulchoir. Back near Paris (in the tiny village of Étiolles) after 1938, Congar became involved in pastoral and ecumenical contacts leading to his great books on *True and False Reform* (1950) and *Toward a Theology of the Laity* (1953). However, soon a period of increasing disruption of his life began that included having his speaking engagements cancelled and finally, in 1954, his exile from Paris at the insistence of the Vatican (the reason given being his teaching for and support of the Priest Worker Movement). Once again, as when he was imprisoned during the war, Congar was distanced from his library and his colleagues and was forced to begin a new episode.

Although he himself was rather little involved in the Priest Worker Movement, he was considered a vital part of the whole movement of the renewal of theology and pastoral life in France that would lead in time to the Council. Along with the three French Dominican provincials and the theologians Dominique Chenu and Henri Féret, Congar was punished by being exiled, first to Jerusalem (where he was kept from accepting a Chair of Theology offered him), then to Cambridge (where he was forbidden to undertake any ministry). In 1956, Bishop Jean-Julien Weber of Strasbourg invited Congar into his diocese with the intention of sheltering him from further misfortune. His Dominican confrères in Strasbourg elected him prior of the community — a sign of their respect and affection.

It is worth noting that the Papal nuncio in Paris at the time of Congar's being exiled was Archbishop Angelo Roncalli (four years later Pope John XXIII), and that he read and annotated his copy of *True and False Reform* with the greatest interest! As pope, he announced the convocation of an ecumenical council only a few months after the beginning of his pontificate and named Yves Congar a consultant to the Preparatory Commission. Congar was also named as a *peritus* for the Theological Commission of the Council. Congar found the work on the commission painfully frustrating, since it was clearly the intention of the Roman curial officials in charge of the commission to maintain the status quo. But in those years Congar's publications multiplied, his Roman

appointment signaled his ecclesiastical rehabilitation, and his influence grew.

During the course of the Council, his contribution was at play in seminars presented to groups of bishops and theologians, in commissions devoted to the preparation of several of the Council documents, and in private consultations with any number of bishops at the Council. He was involved in the preparation of the Vatican II documents on the Church, Revelation, Missions, and the Ministry of Priests. The great wonder of his contribution to the Council is that his life-long program for theological research matched the theological program of Vatican II.

It was almost as if Congar had written a large part of the Council's theological agenda. In 1962, Congar wrote in his Journal:

I saw in the Council an opportunity for the cause not only of unity but also of ecclesiology. I saw it as an occasion, one that needed to be exploited as completely as possible, for accelerating the recovery of the true meaning of "episcopate" and "church" in ecclesiology and for making substantial progress in matters ecumenical. Cited in Guiseppi. Alberigo and Joseph Komonchak, *History of Vatican II*, (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books 1997) Vol. I, 36.

Congar was a man with a fierce sense of justice who remembered and acted from principle and experience. But he was also gifted with an immense irenic patience — able to introduce peace and understanding into difficult situations. This gift was of immense value during the Council, when he found ways to bring unlikely parties into dialogue. One of the great joys of the Council for Congar was seeing the participation of the Protestant and Orthodox observers and helping them to understand and to contribute to this first really ecumenical modern Council.

In the period after the Council, Congar was one of the founders of the international theological journal, *Concilium*, devoted to the dissemination and exploration of the Council's teachings. His personal authority lent great prestige to this important initiative (still thriving today). The meetings of the directors and advisory board of *Concilium* brought him into contact with a new generation of theologians, writers, and thinkers in the Church who broadened his perspectives and revived his hopes.

Because he was always so deeply rooted in history and confident that history is one of the great teachers of the theologian, Congar remained to the end of his life capable of challenging the too easy formulations of ultramontane Roman positions. In his last book, *Eglise et Papauté*, Congar wrote these lines which describe in many ways the theological program of his life:

The relationship between theologians and the magisterium calls for further consideration. First, it should be clear that the status of the magisterium in the Church cannot be isolat-

ed from the living reality of the Church. We must recognize the originality of the charism and the service of theologians, the specific need for their work within the faith community of the Church, and clarify the conditions for the healthy exercise of their role. They must possess a sense of responsibility and a feeling of communion with the ordinary life of the faithful, but also witness to doxology and the celebration of the Christian mysteries; they must be open to criticism, mutually expressed. It would be wrong to define the situation of theologians as dependent uniquely upon the magisterium, even if that remained true to itself. . . . Rather the matter must be thought out in terms of three elements: above all the *truth*, i.e., the apostolic faith. . . , next, at its service, the magisterium of the apostolic ministry *and* the work and teaching of theologians, and then finally the faith of Christian believers. (pp. 314-5)

Yves Congar was ninety years old and in constantly failing health when, in 1994, he was named a cardinal of the universal Church. Only in the last year of his life did a pope accord him the official title of “Eminence.” But he had already spent sixty years as an eminent ecumenical theologian in the Christian world, admired and appreciated by Orthodox, Anglican, and Protestant church leaders for the clarity, love, and courage of his theology and personal witness.

His elevation to the College of Cardinals not only recognized his long life of scholarship and his immense contributions to the Church’s theological patrimony and contemporary renewal, but also his steadfast loyalty to a Church that had treated him unjustly. He was a man of unyielding faith and indefatigable vision, made strong by a love of his Dominican vocation and a vast network of colleagues and disciples.

As a personality, Congar the man was clearly a Type A temperament — impatient with trivia, his mind running ahead toward a stable thesis (a resting point) in complex argument, ceaselessly working day and night on his books and articles. But his was a personality transformed by pastoral compassion, ecumenical love, and a passion for the truth. Some twenty-five years ago, Providence College, the Dominican Liberal Arts College in Rhode Island, dedicated a study center to Yves Congar and informed him of this sign of affection and recognition. Congar wrote an appreciative and encouraging letter of thanks to the Dominican faculty of the college that ended with the words: “*Au travail, mes frères*” — “Let’s get to work, Brothers!” I remember Yves Congar in that way. For him work was the service of the word of God for the sake of the people of God. Nothing was too much to ask for such a vocation.